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Tactics and Calculation in 1.d4 2.c4 Positions

Opening-specific geometry, central breaks, candidate moves, and blunder control

COURSE BOOK

20 focused chapters - model positions - decision rules - retrieval practice

Designed to change what you notice, calculate, remember, and do at the board.

How to Use This Course

ONE CHAPTER, FOUR PASSES

1. Read the position without moving pieces. 2. State your plan and the opponent's counterplay. 3. Study the decision rules. 4. Close the book and reconstruct the position from memory.

RETRIEVAL SCHEDULE

Review the chapter the next day, one week later, and after a game that reaches a similar structure. Retrieval is more valuable than rereading.

BOARD ROUTINE

Opponent's threat - forcing moves - loose pieces - worst piece - central break - best reply - choose and stop.

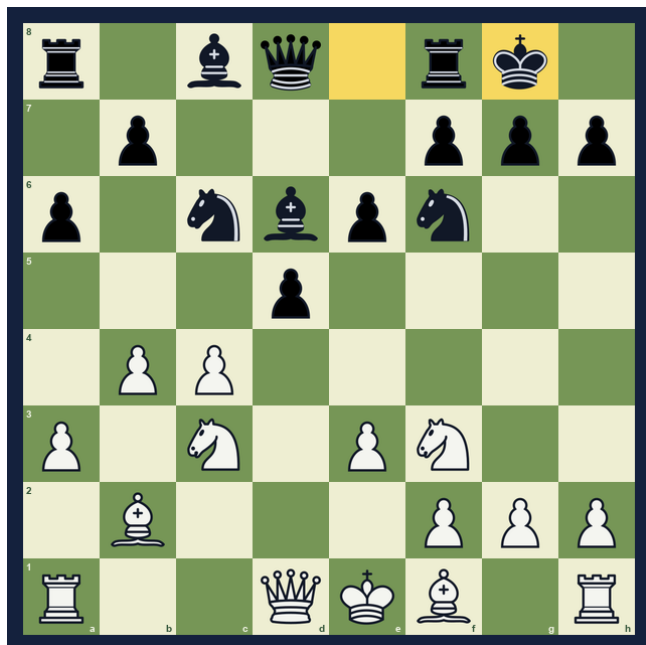
The course book explains each model position. The separate workbook forces recall, prediction, and self-scoring. Use the book first, then attempt the matching workbook page without looking back.

Engine evaluations are intentionally not the lesson. The aim is to store human decision rules that remain useful when the exact move order changes.

Course Map

MODULE	CHAPTERS
TACTICS AND CALCULATION	20

01. Loose Pieces Tell the Truth



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Many opening tactics begin with an undefended or overloaded piece.

PRIMARY PLAN

Count attackers and defenders before following remembered theory.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. e3 Nf6 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. a3 a6 7. dxc5 Bxc5 8. b4 Bd6 9. Bb2 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Loose pieces create forcing candidates.

01. Decision Framework

Loose Pieces Tell the Truth

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

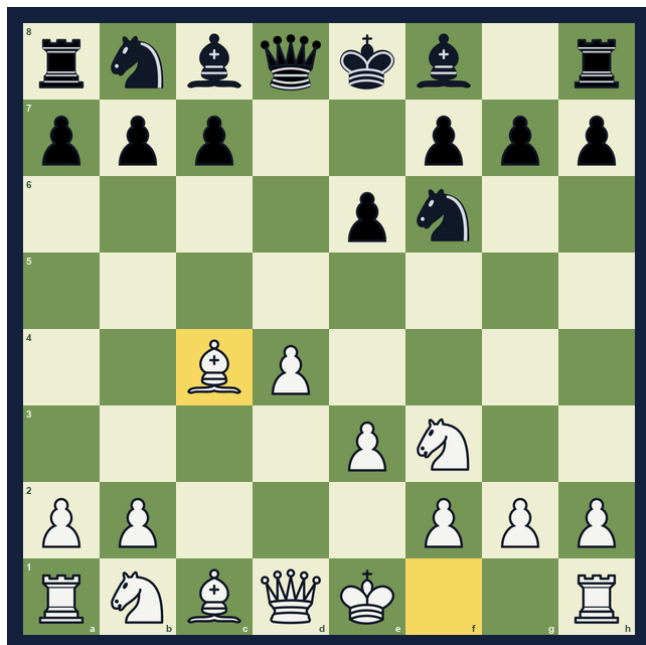
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Loose pieces create forcing candidates.

02. Checks, Captures, and Threats



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Forcing moves define the tactical boundary of the position.

PRIMARY PLAN

List them for both sides before selecting a positional move.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4

MEMORY RULE

Scan forcing moves before trusting a plan.

02. Decision Framework

Checks, Captures, and Threats

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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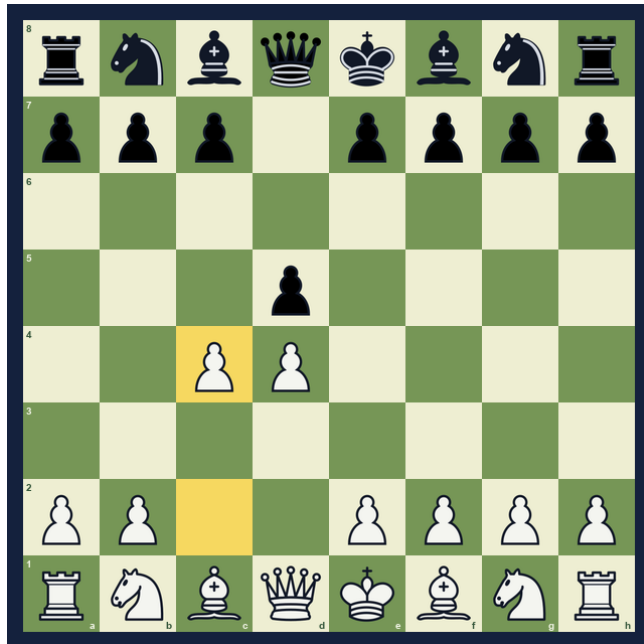
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Scan forcing moves before trusting a plan.

03. Calculate the Central Break



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

e4, e5, c5, and b5 change several lines at once.

PRIMARY PLAN

Visualize the forced recapture and the first open-line move.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4

MEMORY RULE

A pawn break is a multi-piece tactic.

03. Decision Framework

Calculate the Central Break

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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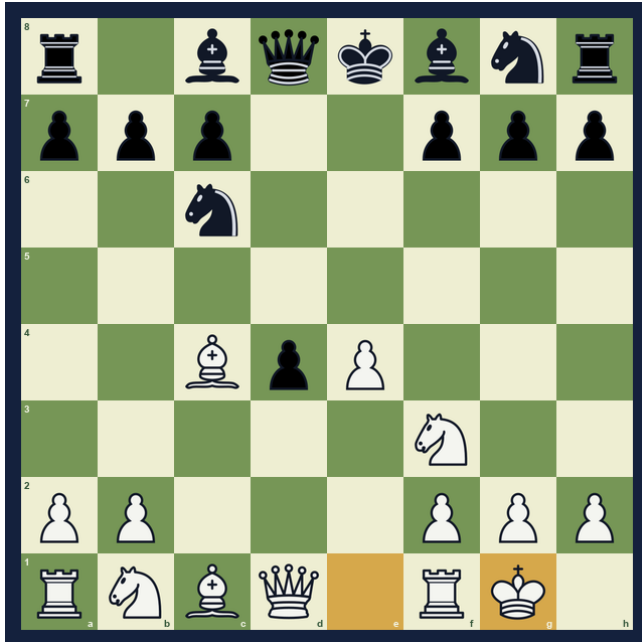
ACTIVE RECALL

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2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A pawn break is a multi-piece tactic.

04. The cxd5 Decision



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Capturing on d5 changes the c-file, e-file, and pawn targets.

PRIMARY PLAN

Calculate each recapture and compare the resulting piece activity.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. e4 e5 4. Nf3 exd4 5. Bxc4 Nc6 6. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Recapture choice defines the middlegame.

04. Decision Framework

The cxd5 Decision

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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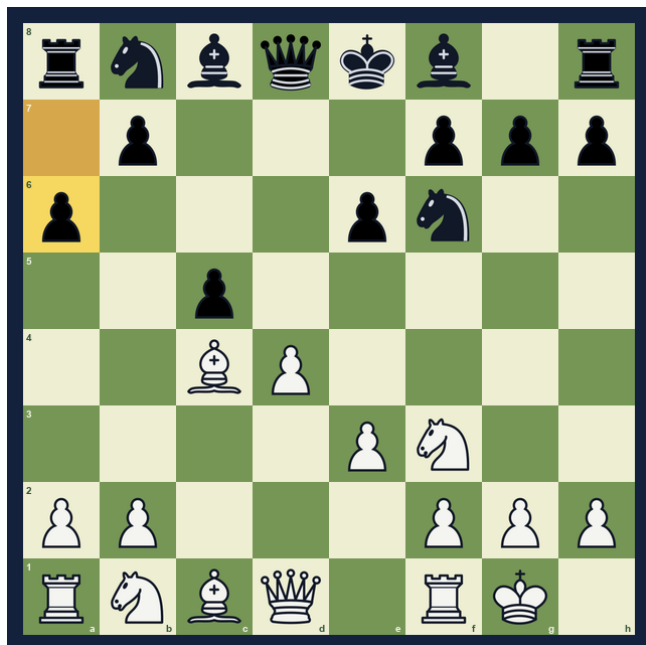
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Recapture choice defines the middlegame.

05. Choose the Right Recapture



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Pawn, knight, queen, or piece recaptures can create different structures.

PRIMARY PLAN

Compare material, tempo, file control, and future breaks.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 dxc4 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. e3 e6 5. Bxc4 c5 6. O-O a6

MEMORY RULE

A recapture is a plan selection.

05. Decision Framework

Choose the Right Recapture

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A recapture is a plan selection.

06. Punish a Pawn Grab



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Holding c4 or b5 can leave Black behind in development.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use development with tempo and open lines rather than chasing the pawn with the queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Bg5 Be7 6. e3 O-O 7. Bd3 Nbd7 8. Qc2 Re8 9. Nge2 Nf8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Attack the position created by the pawn grab.

06. Decision Framework

Punish a Pawn Grab

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Attack the position created by the pawn grab.

07. Pins on c6 and f6



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

A pinned knight may still move when the piece behind it is not the king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify what is actually pinned and calculate the tactical consequence.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

Name the protected object before believing a pin.

07. Decision Framework

Pins on c6 and f6

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Name the protected object before believing a pin.

08. Qa4+ Geometry



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

A queen check can recover c4, attack c6, or force a blocking piece.

PRIMARY PLAN

Check Black's interpositions and resulting queen exposure.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 c6 6. Bg5 Be7 7. Qc2 O-O 8. e3 Nbd7 9. Bd3 Re8 10. O-O

MEMORY RULE

A check is useful when the forced reply helps development.

08. Decision Framework

Qa4+ Geometry

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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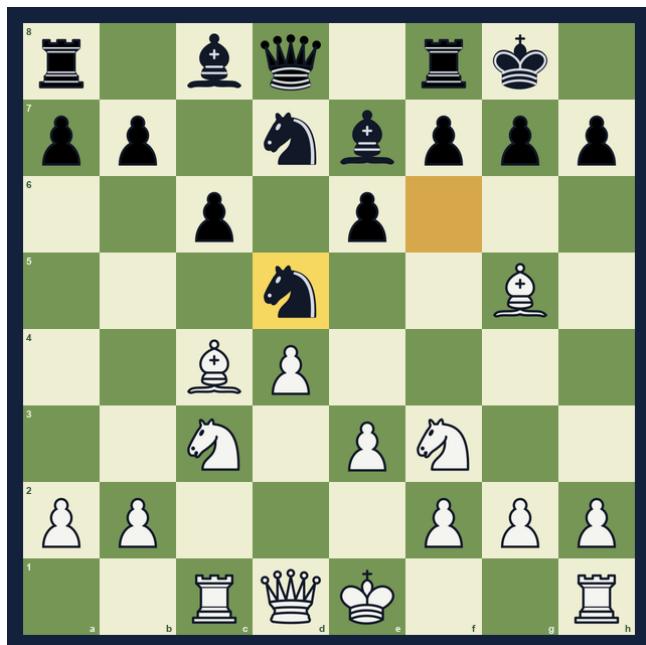
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A check is useful when the forced reply helps development.

09. e4 and e5 Break Tactics



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Central pawn advances can fork pieces or open a bishop and rook simultaneously.

PRIMARY PLAN

Calculate captures, knight retreats, and discovered lines.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

The break's geometry matters more than the pawn itself.

09. Decision Framework

e4 and e5 Break Tactics

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The break's geometry matters more than the pawn itself.

10. Long-Diagonal Tactics



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Fianchetto bishops create pins, skewers, and attacks on queenside rooks.

PRIMARY PLAN

Trace the full diagonal after every central pawn move.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 h6 7. Bh4 b6 8. cxd5 exd5 9. Bd3 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

A pawn move can reveal a distant tactic.

10. Decision Framework

Long-Diagonal Tactics

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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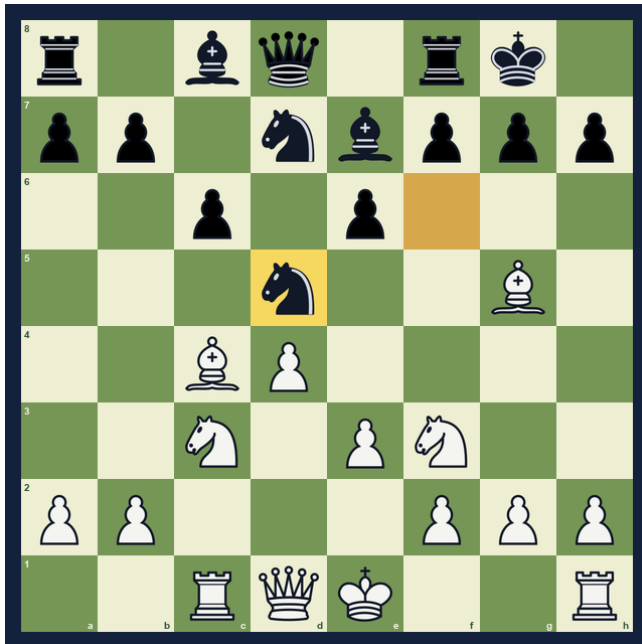
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: A pawn move can reveal a distant tactic.

11. Benko a-File Tactics



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Open queenside files allow rook sacrifices and pressure on b2.

PRIMARY PLAN

Control entry squares and test every exchange sacrifice before assuming safety.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Bg5 Be7 5. e3 O-O 6. Nf3 Nbd7 7. Rc1 c6 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 Nd5

MEMORY RULE

Open files are tactical assets when the king and queen are tied down.

11. Decision Framework

Benko a-File Tactics

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
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5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Open files are tactical assets when the king and queen are tied down.

12. King's Indian Sacrifices



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Closed centers often permit sacrifices on f2, g3, or h3.

PRIMARY PLAN

Count attackers, defensive exchanges, and the route of Black's queen.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 Bb4 5. cxd5 exd5 6. Bg5 h6 7. Bh4 c5 8. e3 Nc6 9. Bd3 cxd4 10. exd4 O-O

MEMORY RULE

Closed centers shift calculation toward the king.

12. Decision Framework

King's Indian Sacrifices

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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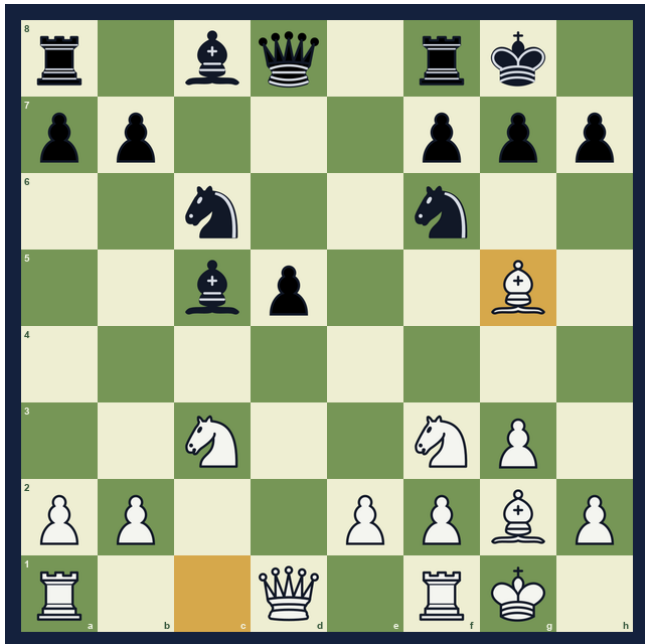
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Closed centers shift calculation toward the king.

13. Clearance



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

A pawn advance or exchange can clear a file, diagonal, or square for another piece.

PRIMARY PLAN

Ask which piece becomes stronger after the square is vacated.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 c5 4. cxd5 exd5 5. Nf3 Nc6 6. g3 Nf6 7. Bg2 Be7 8. O-O O-O 9. dxc5 Bxc5 10. Bg5

MEMORY RULE

The moving piece may not be the point of the move.

13. Decision Framework

Clearance

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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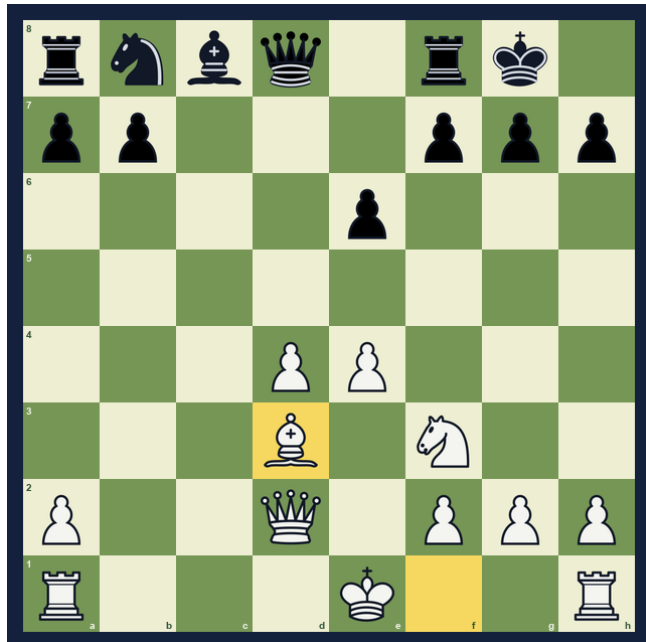
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3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The moving piece may not be the point of the move.

14. Overload



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

A defender can be responsible for a pawn, square, and tactical line at once.

PRIMARY PLAN

Remove or distract the defender before attacking the target.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 e6 3. Nc3 Nf6 4. Nf3 c5 5. cxd5 Nxd5 6. e4 Nxc3 7. bxc3 cxd4 8. cxd4 Bb4+ 9. Bd2 Bxd2+ 10. Qxd2 O-O 11. Bd3

MEMORY RULE

Count jobs, not only attackers.

14. Decision Framework

Overload

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

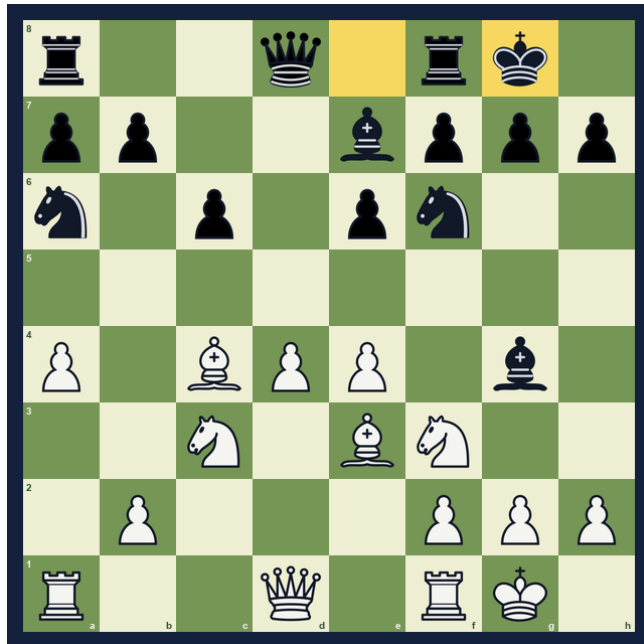
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Count jobs, not only attackers.

15. Deflection



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

A forcing move can pull a piece away from the center or king.

PRIMARY PLAN

Identify what becomes loose after the defender moves.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Na6 6. e4 Bg4 7. Bxc4 e6 8. O-O Be7 9. Be3 O-O

MEMORY RULE

The destination of the defender reveals the tactic.

15. Decision Framework

Deflection

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

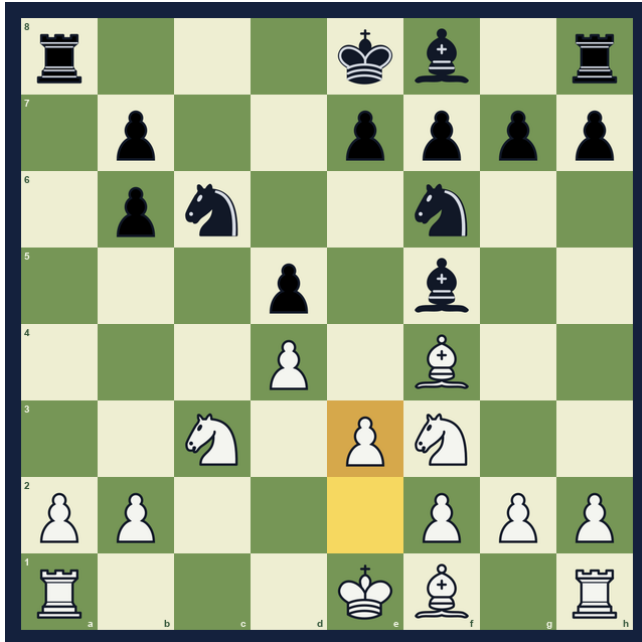
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: The destination of the defender reveals the tactic.

16. Intermediate Moves



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

An in-between check, capture, or threat can change an expected recapture sequence.

PRIMARY PLAN

Before recapturing automatically, scan every forcing move.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 Bf5 5. cxd5 cxd5 6. Qb3 Qb6 7. Qxb6 axb6 8. Bf4 Nc6 9. e3

MEMORY RULE

Recapture last after checking forcing moves first.

16. Decision Framework

Intermediate Moves

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

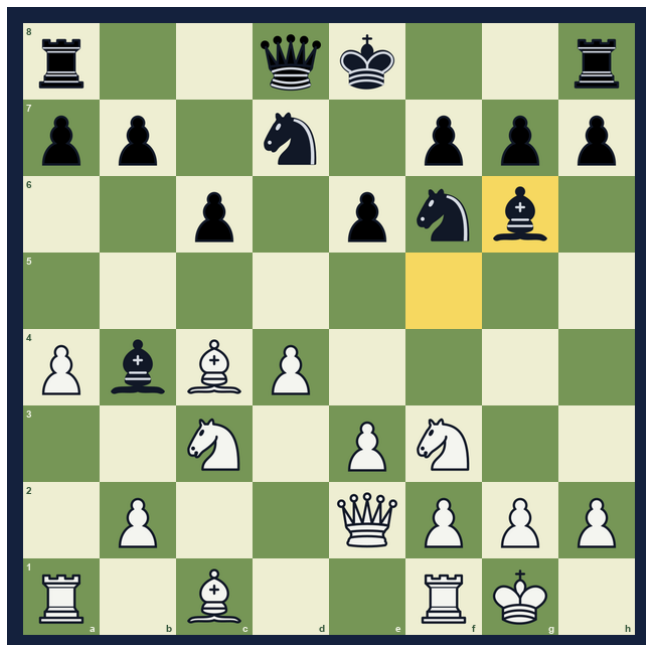
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Recapture last after checking forcing moves first.

17. Generate Serious Candidates



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

A useful candidate comes from forcing moves, the structural plan, or Black's best resource.

PRIMARY PLAN

Limit the first pass to two or three moves that answer the position.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 dxc4 5. a4 Bf5 6. e3 e6 7. Bxc4 Bb4 8. O-O Nbd7 9. Qe2 Bg6

MEMORY RULE

Candidates must solve a problem.

17. Decision Framework

Generate Serious Candidates

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

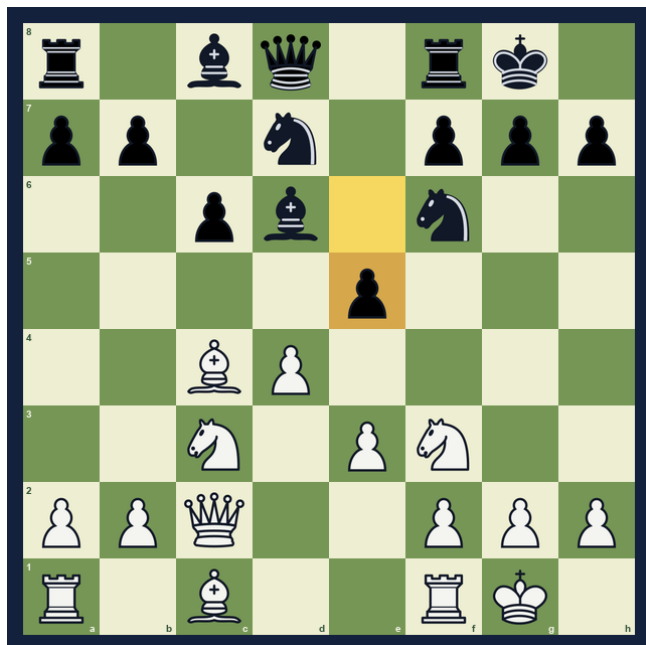
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Candidates must solve a problem.

18. Visualize the Final Position



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Calculation fails when pieces from earlier branches remain in the mental picture.

PRIMARY PLAN

Recount material, king safety, pawn structure, and loose pieces at the first quiet position.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. e3 Nbd7 6. Qc2 Bd6 7. Bd3 O-O 8. O-O dxc4 9. Bxc4 e5

MEMORY RULE

Evaluate the end of the line, not its first move.

18. Decision Framework

Visualize the Final Position

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

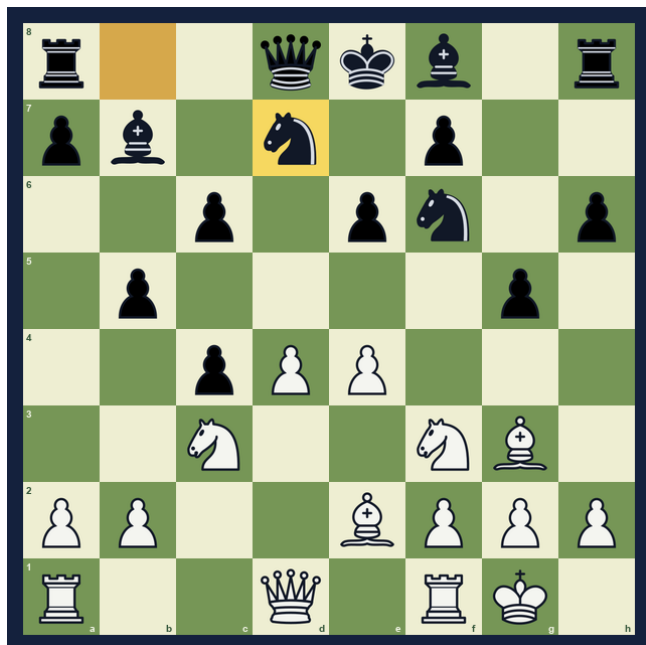
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Evaluate the end of the line, not its first move.

19. Know When to Stop



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

Calculation should stop when one safe move satisfies the plan against Black's best reply.

PRIMARY PLAN

Use a stopping rule instead of searching for perfection.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bh4 dxc4 7. e4 g5 8. Bg3 b5 9. Be2 Bb7 10. O-O Nbd7

MEMORY RULE

Safe, purposeful, and satisfactory is enough.

19. Decision Framework

Know When to Stop

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
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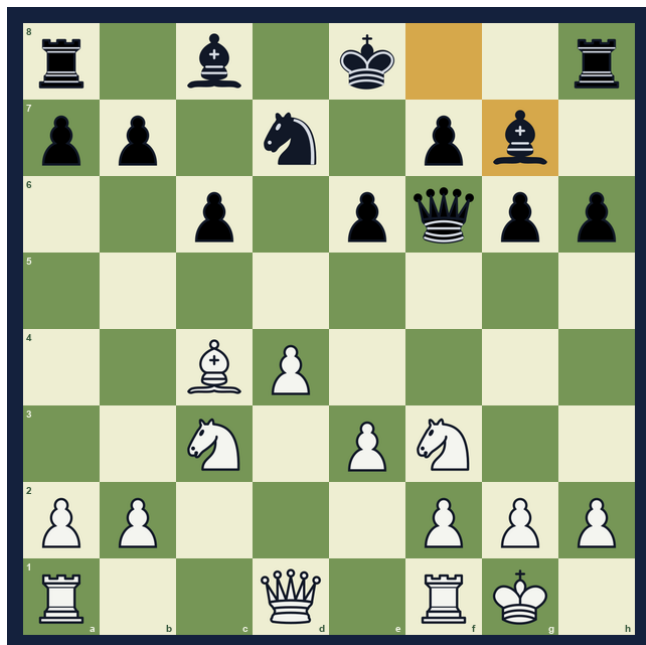
ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
2. What is your first useful plan, and which piece must improve before the pawn break?
3. What is the opponent's best freeing move or tactical resource?
4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Safe, purposeful, and satisfactory is enough.

20. Final Blunder Check



TACTICS AND CALCULATION

READ THE POSITION

The last scan catches hanging pieces and one-move tactical replies.

PRIMARY PLAN

After choosing, ask what Black's strongest check, capture, and threat will be.

OPPONENT'S COUNTERPLAY

Black's best resource is the freeing move, tactical exchange, or piece improvement that challenges this plan.

REFERENCE LINE

1. d4 d5 2. c4 c6 3. Nf3 Nf6 4. Nc3 e6 5. Bg5 h6 6. Bxf6 Qxf6 7. e3 Nd7 8. Bd3 dxc4 9. Bxc4 g6 10. O-O Bg7

MEMORY RULE

Choose, scan once, then move.

20. Decision Framework

Final Blunder Check

PAWN BREAK / TRANSFORMATION	Before an irreversible pawn move, picture the forced recapture, new files, new diagonals, and the first piece to use them.
PIECE JOB	Identify the least active piece and give it a route that supports the structure's main break or target.
TACTICAL WARNING	Verify the plan with checks, captures, threats, loose pieces, pins, and Black's strongest reply.
TRADE FILTER	Exchange only after naming the favorable feature that survives the recapture.
ENDGAME FORECAST	Forecast the king activity, pawn targets, files, majorities, and minor-piece quality that survive simplification.
CLOCK RULE	Spend time on forcing or irreversible choices; move efficiently only in a position you truly recognize.

ACTIVE RECALL

1. Without looking back, describe the center and the position's main imbalance.
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4. Which exchange helps, which exchange helps the opponent, and what survives into the ending?
5. State the memory rule in your own words and name one trigger that would change the plan.

NEXT-GAME ASSIGNMENT

If a similar structure appears, pause before the first irreversible decision and use this rule: Choose, scan once, then move.

Course Completion Test

Choose ten chapters at random. Rebuild each reference position, name both sides' plans, identify the critical break, and state the trade filter without reopening the chapter.

Score one point for the structure, one for your plan, one for counterplay, one for the break, and one for the memory rule. Forty out of fifty means the knowledge is usable; below forty means retrieval practice should continue.

FINAL PRINCIPLE

A course is complete when its ideas appear in your decisions, not when its pages have been read.